

ASPERGER AND THE ONTOLOGICAL BLACK SWAN

Are nerds more blind to swans? Social skills in Extremistan—On the immortality of Dr. Greenspan

If *The Black Swan* is about epistemic limitations, then, from this definition, we can see that it is not about some objectively defined phenomenon, like rain or a car crash—it is simply something that was not expected by a *particular* observer.

So I was wondering why so many otherwise intelligent people have casually questioned whether certain events, say the Great War, or the September 11, 2001, attack on the World Trade Center, were Black Swans, on the grounds that *some* predicted them. Of course the September 11 attack was a Black Swan to those victims who died in it; otherwise, they would not have exposed themselves to the risk. But it was certainly not a Black Swan to the terrorists who planned and carried out the attack. I have spent considerable time away from the weight-lifting room repeating that *a Black Swan for the turkey is not a Black Swan for the butcher*.

The same applies to the crisis of 2008, certainly a Black Swan to almost all economists, journalists, and financiers on this planet (including, predictably, Robert Merton and Myron Scholes, the turkeys of [Chapter 17](#)), but certainly not to this author. (Incidentally, as an illustration of another common mistake, almost none of those—very few—who seemed to have “predicted” the event predicted its depth. We will see that, because of the atypicality of events in Extremistan, the Black Swan is not just about the occurrence of some event but also about its depth and consequences.)

ASPERGER PROBABILITY

This consideration of an *objective* Black Swan, one that would be the same to all observers, aside from missing the point completely, seems dangerously related to the problem of underdevelopment of a human faculty called “theory of mind” or “folk psychology.” Some people, otherwise intelligent, have a deficiency of that human ability to impute